

money lines between us. It wasn't until we were back from living abroad that I began to notice when the neighbors bought a brand-new car or had gone to Disneyland over Christmas. But when I'd tell my parents by way of wanting to prod something similar out of them, they'd just shrug and say, "That's nice for them." They weren't the "keeping up with the Joneses" type of parents.

So next time your child runs into the house declaring that the next-door neighbor just got the latest Xbox, use it as an opportunity to explain how unimportant all that stuff is, and that competing for neighborhood prominence using pools, cars, and video consoles isn't a game you play.

Kids pick up on their parents' attitudes about money. If you and your partner have a healthy relationship with money, and can speak openly and freely about what money is and isn't, then chances are good your child will absorb those positive messages. But if money is a central complaint in the family, and your fights revolve around the lack of money, or bad spending habits, then you might be sending dangerous messages about money.